

July 20, 2026

Sam Chappell and the Axial Search team

Re: Fractional Chief AI Officer candidate network

Axial Search's posting is unusually honest about the market: organizations often need senior AI leadership before they are ready to define or carry a permanent Chief AI Officer role. That interim period is precisely where expensive false starts are created - or prevented.

My candidacy is built around a simple operating premise: a fractional CAIO should leave more than a strategy deck. The engagement should produce a mandate the board can govern, a portfolio the organization can execute, and an ownership system the permanent leader can inherit. That means making outcomes, decision rights, technical choices, guardrails, adoption responsibility, and handoff conditions explicit from the beginning.

Since 2017, through DudeWorth, I have developed AI-readiness and opportunity frameworks that connect business value, feasibility, data readiness, governance, adoption burden, reuse, and time-to-value. I work directly with agentic workflow patterns, structured context, retrieval, human judgment, escalation, evaluation, and governance rails. As Director of Operations at Vape-Jet, I lead AI-first operating transformation across production, quality, purchasing, support, customer success, engineering issue flow, ERP/Odoo, Jira, HubSpot, Slack, telemetry, and AI-assisted work in a robotics and machine-vision environment.

That AI work sits on a deeper operating foundation. At Amazon, I led launch and execution in a 24/7 customer-backward system supporting approximately five million second-day orders annually. At Compunetics, I led engineering, manufacturing, quality, customer delivery, and high-reliability technical programs involving organizations including DoD, CERN, Intel, and AMD. Across those settings, the recurring work has been the same: make complexity visible, connect technical and business teams, create decision mechanisms, and turn change into adopted operating behavior.

I believe that background maps well to Axial's Three-Lens model. Strategic Judgment is visible in portfolio and operating-system design. Technical Acumen is visible in direct AI workflow, architecture-pattern, evaluation, and automation work. Change Leadership is visible in launches, standard work, coaching, cross-functional accountability, and capability transfer. The complete candidate vision at <https://russelldudek.github.io/Axial/> demonstrates this through a Fractional AI Mandate Charter, a 120-day entry plan, and an interview thesis tailored to the way Axial matches leaders to mandates rather than titles.

I would welcome a conversation about the client contexts where Axial sees the greatest need for an operator-technologist: someone comfortable advising the board, working with technical leaders, challenging weak investment logic, and entering the workflows where adoption and value are actually won.

Carpe diem,

Russell Dudek